

Activating Rural America Advisory Group

Physical Activity Research Center



Making physical activity an everyday experience for all children

Physical Activity Research Center



UC San Diego

Sponsor



Robert Wood Johnson Foundation



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PARC Core Research Studies

- Youth Physical Activity in Summer: Patterns and Disparities
- Youth Engagement and Action for Health!
- Promoting Safe Places to Play: Implementation of Play Streets in Diverse Low-Income Rural Communities
- Physical Activity and Recreation in Children in Communities of Color – PARC3



PARC Commissioned Study Projects

- Evaluating the California Distinguished After School Health Program- Supplemental Physical Activity Component
- Decision Making toward Successful Physical Activity Practices in Schools
- Effective School Investment in Physical Activity: Calibrating Costs and Benefits
- Evidence to Inform a Cycling and Walking Investment Strategy
- Best Practices in Engaging Public Health in Complete Streets Policy Actions



Voices for Healthy Kids



- Advocacy initiative with the goal of **reversing childhood obesity through policy change in disproportionately affected areas.**
- *Activating Rural America* is an Innovation, Equity and Exploration special project workgroup (IEE).
 - Designed to mobilize broad expertise, perspectives and advocacy capacity in an engagement model around health equity and the social determinants of health.
 - Goal: Advance the public policy agenda of the initiative.



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Voices for Healthy Kids Policy Priorities - Schools

- **Healthy, Equitable Schools:** Promote the Whole School, Whole Community, Whole Child (WSCSS) model to support and build broad and inclusive healthy, school environments, particularly in marginalized or under-resourced communities. Work to support and build healthy schools for all children regardless of where they live or go to school. Specific policies include:
 - **Physical activity:** Support physical activity opportunities that promote active transportation policy such as safe routes to school programs, recess, classroom physical activity breaks and in other after school programs.



Voices for Healthy Kids Policy Priorities - Active Travel

- **Active, Equitable Communities:** Support state and local policies and funding, and influence the use of federal dollars in states, that make communities and neighborhoods more livable by ensuring all people can get safely to where they need to go – work, school, the library, grocery stores, or parks, starting where the needs are greatest. Specific policies include:
 - **Complete streets:** Require that all road construction and reconstruction at the state, regional and community levels create complete streets that are safe and convenient for all users and all modes of transportation.
 - **Bike and pedestrian appropriations:** Support state, regional and local financing mechanisms that create equitable, long-term funding for bicycling and walking projects and encourage programs for communities most in need.



Welcome and Introductions

- Introductions
 - Name
 - Organization
 - What is one **key resource** that you would recommend to rural community leaders who are trying to increase physical activity in their neighborhood?
- Leadership Team
 - [Renée Umstattd Meyer](#), Principal Investigator, Baylor University
 - [Christiaan Abildso](#), Co-Investigator, West Virginia University
 - [Amanda Walker](#), Project Coordinator, UC San Diego
 - [Christina Bridges Hamilton](#), Project Staff, Baylor University
 - [Michelle Pennington](#), Project Staff, Baylor University



Introductions

- Voices for Healthy Kids Team
 - [NaDa Shoemaker](#), National Partnership Manager – Coalitions, Voices for Healthy Kids, American Heart Association
 - [Marla Hollander](#), National Partnership Manager, Voices for Healthy Kids, American Heart Association
 - [Claudia Goytia](#), State and Community Advocacy Manager, American Heart Association, Voices for Healthy Kids, American Heart Association
 - [Aaron Doeppers](#), Senior Manager of Strategic Partnerships, Voices for Healthy Kids, American Heart Association



Advisory Group Introductions

- Safe Routes to School
 - [Sara Zimmerman](#), Program & Policy Director, Safe Routes Partnership
- Complete Streets
 - [Emiko Atherton](#), Director, National Complete Streets Coalition, Smart Growth America
 - [Karin Valentine Goins](#), Research Project Director, UMass Worcester Prevention Research Center
 - [Beth Osborne](#), Director, Transportation for America, Smart Growth America
 - [Emily Schweninger](#), Deputy Director, Thriving Communities, Smart Growth America



Advisory Group Introductions

- Bike and Pedestrian Appropriations
 - [Angie Cradock](#), Senior Research Scientist, Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health
 - [Andrew Dupuy](#), Manager of Policy Outreach, Rails-to-Trails Conservancy
 - [Kate Kraft](#), Executive Director, America Walks
 - [Ken McLeod](#), Policy Director, The League of American Bicyclists
 - [Katie Selin](#), Planner, Alta Planning
- Community and Health Equity
 - [Noah Lenstra](#), Assistant Professor, University of North Carolina at Greensboro
 - [Laurie Whitsel](#), Vice President of Policy Research and Translation, American Heart Association



Our Purpose

- Overall Goal

- To inform Voices for Healthy Kids of rural practices and challenges regarding the active living-related policy levers, with specific attention to health equity.

- Advisory Group

- National advocacy organizations will provide a higher-level perspective, review and provide feedback on methods and materials, and assist with dissemination.

- Workgroup

- Scan and synthesize policy and advocacy literature and web presence and survey and/or interview key decision makers of rural communities engaged in this work.
- 1-2 calls / month to accomplish project goal, produce the deliverables, and learn from guest speakers.



Deliverables

- **Identify and describe current rural efforts** to adapt and advance the Voices for Healthy Kids active living policy levers, with specific attention to approaches or challenges related to **health equity** in rural communities.
- Provide recommendations and considerations to Voices for Healthy Kids for **next steps in continuing or modifying policy levers for rural communities**.
- Create **summaries of lessons learned** from workgroup activities that could be distributed to a variety of stakeholders with interests in rural health and physical activity.
- **Develop a prioritized set of research questions** that could fill gaps in understanding and developing solutions for inequities in physical activity opportunities for rural youth.



Timeline

Timeframe	Objective
July – Sept 2019	Workgroup planning
Oct 2019	Invite workgroup members, advisory group members, and speakers; schedule workgroup and advisory group launch calls
Nov 2019	Hold first workgroup and advisory group calls
Nov 2019 - June 2020	Schedule 1-2 workgroup calls per month; hold quarterly advisory group calls; send out bi-monthly newsletters
Feb 2020	In-person meeting at the Active Living Conference for those in attendance
Jan – Apr 2020	Conduct interviews and surveys with rural community leaders and advocacy groups
Apr – June 2020	Develop a prioritized set of research questions for Voices for Healthy Kids; provide recommendations and considerations to Voices for Healthy Kids for next steps in continuing to modify active living policy levers for rural communities



Progress Update

- Grey literature search
- Google news scan
- We want your feedback!



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Grey Literature Search

Grey literature includes reports, government documents, evaluations, policies, newsletters, blogs, etc.



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Grey Literature Search

■ **Methods**

- Google Search terms:
 - “safe routes to school”
 - “complete streets”
 - “bicycle pedestrian appropriations” / “bicycle appropriations” / “pedestrian appropriations” / “bike/ped appropriations”
 - AND “rural”
 - AND *state name* (including the District of Columbia)
- Search included resources that were for or pertained to rural areas, or included sections/information for rural areas

■ **Results**

- Safe Routes to School: 30 resources
- Complete Streets & Bike/Ped Appropriations: 86 resources
 - Combined due to overlap



Examples - Safe Routes to School



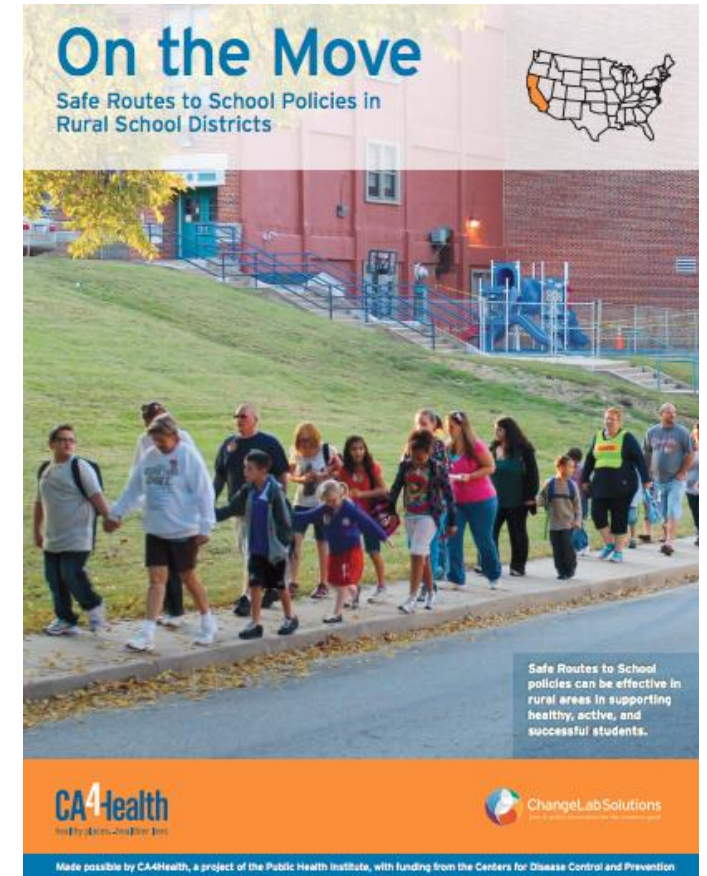
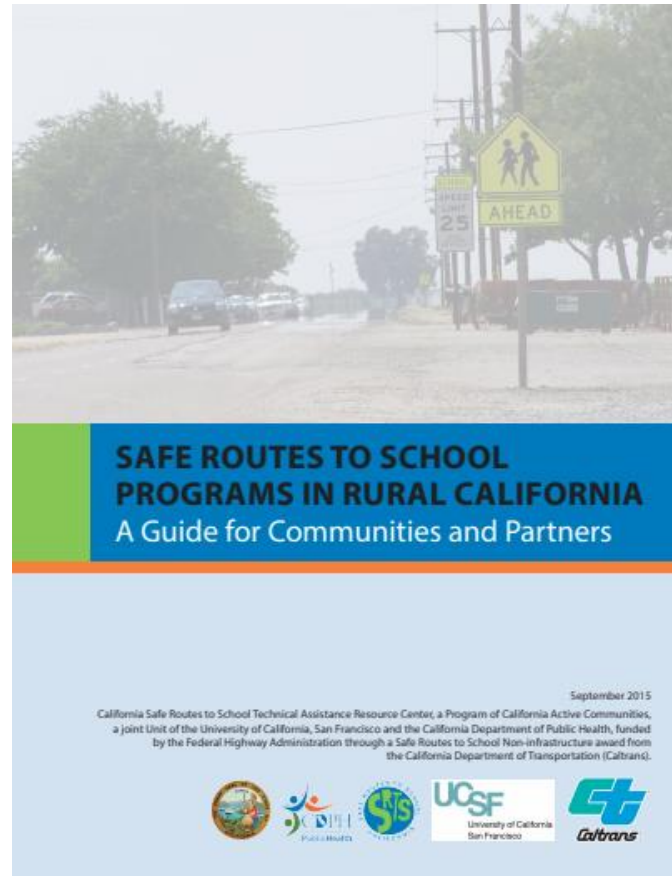
Rural Communities: Best Practices and Promising Approaches for Safe Routes



Safe Routes to School programs can succeed in rural areas. But ensuring that schoolchildren can get the benefits of walking and bicycling to school in rural communities requires dealing with some challenges and barriers that may be different than in other areas. This tipsheet delves into these issues. It describes the needs for and benefits of Safe Routes to School in rural areas, explores the challenges that may arise, spells out specific approaches that show promise, and showcases successful rural examples.



www.saferroutespartnership.org



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Examples - Complete Streets and Bike Ped Appropriations

NSPAPPH Annual Conference

May 2012

Complete Streets in Rural Montana

Cathy Costakis
Active Living Coordinator
Montana Nutrition and Physical Activity Program



BENEFITS OF COMPLETE STREETS

Complete Streets Work in Rural Communities

By planning, designing, and constructing Complete Streets, communities of all sizes - whether rural hamlets, small towns, or booming metropolises - are able to provide the quality access to jobs, health care, shops, and schools their residents deserve, while also achieving greater economic, environmental, and public health benefits. A Complete Streets approach can provide a more effective and balanced transportation system for the nearly 49 million Americans who live in rural areas and small towns.



Photos: Dan Burden, Walkable and Livable Communities Institute



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Grey Literature Search

- **Themes**

- Safe Routes to School
 - Remote drop off
 - Walking school bus
 - Walk to school day
 - Bike rodeo/rally
- Complete Streets & Bike/Ped Appropriations
 - Road improvements (paved shoulders, traffic calming measures, signage)
 - Policies



News Scan



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News Scan

- **Methods**

- Google News & Google News Archives
- Search terms:
 - “safe routes to school”
 - “complete streets”
 - “bicycle pedestrian appropriations” / “bicycle appropriations” / “pedestrian appropriations” / “bike/ped appropriations” / “bicycle improvements” / “pedestrian improvements”
- Inclusion criteria
 - Viewable (i.e. did not require subscription)
 - Pertained to rural communities in the US as determined using RUCA codes



News Scan

- **Results**

- Safe Routes to School: 37 articles
- Complete Streets: 11 articles
- Bike/Pedestrian Appropriations: 30 articles
 - Still searching additional bike/ped terms
 - E.g. search terms: funding, infrastructure



Examples - Safe Routes to School

- A smoother path to Lincoln School after Safe Routes to School Grant
- Garfield County Bike to School Day set for May 14
- Pendleton School District to host meetings on bike and walking routes to school
- Red crosswalks change school traffic for better
- Waynesboro police sharing pedestrian safety tips with students this week
- Woodbine, Elementary School Recognized for Safe Routes to School



Examples - Complete Streets

- Council Approves Robin Drive Street Plan After Contentious Debate
- City of Hollister awarded transportation planning grant to develop Complete Streets Plan
- City, residents look for 'complete street' ideas
- Shared-use path nearing completion
- Great Barrington eyes funding for five 'complete streets' projects: They're not just for cars |
- Here's why downtown Farmington Complete Streets construction has been delayed until 2020



Examples - Bike and Pedestrian Appropriations

- Bedford town officials plan crosswalk, pedestrian improvements near Liberty Lake Park
- City of Cape May to Solicit Suggestions for Proposed Bikeway Expansion Project During Public Info Session
- Cycling Association donates bike rack to Utica Public Library
- In Chincoteague, bicycle path across causeway proposed
- Rehoboth Beach Paves the Path to the Future of Pedestrian Safety
- GO Sedona Bicycle and Pedestrian wikimap launched for your input



Next Steps

- Any suggestions on how to expand the scans?
- Please help identify communities for potential surveys / key informant interviews.
 - We will send a Google Form after our call today to collect your ideas.
 - Please tell us about any communities you know of, including your own!
 - The workgroup will be meeting two more times in December to solidify methods for collecting this information.
 - We will bring these ideas to the Advisory Group for feedback in January.
- **Next Call:** January (Date/Time TBD)
 - Please think about the types of questions we should ask to understand what rural communities are doing in these policy areas.

